



PRODUCT DESIGNER

JOB DESCRIPTION

Almost every object or device used in everyday life—from a chair to a computer—has been shaped by a product designer. In addition to creating new items, a product designer may also improve existing ones or make them more cost-effective. The design process is collaborative; product designers develop ideas with clients, work on prototypes with engineers, and assist marketing staff in promoting the product to buyers.



SALARY

Product designer ★★★★★

Design engineer ★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Highly competitive • Huge demand for innovative product designers • Jobs available with manufacturers or specialized product design agencies

▼ RELATED CAREERS

- ▶ **INTERIOR DESIGNER** *see pp. 34–35*
- ▶ **ARCHITECTURAL TECHNICIAN** Supports an architect on the practical aspects of a construction project. An architectural technician prepares drawings and blueprints, sources suitable materials, and oversees legal and planning issues.
- ▶ **DESIGN ENGINEER** Conceptualizes and develops new products as well as their manufacturing processes. Testing prototypes to ensure products function correctly and are reliable is also part of this job.

**There are more than
40,000 product designers
working in the United
States alone.**

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Art and design • Engineering • Craft technology • Graphic design • Physics • Mathematics • History



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS An undergraduate degree in product design, industrial design, or engineering is required to enter this profession.



LIFESTYLE Product designers work regular office hours but need to be flexible to meet deadlines. Most of the design work is done on computers.



LOCATION Most product designers are based in offices or studios, but they may need to travel to meet clients or conduct research with the product's users.



THE REALITIES This is a competitive field where designers need to keep up with new technologies and design trends. Networking is key to career progression.